



LORENZO TUGNOLI FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A photo of Bashar al-Assad is taken off the wall of a regime prison in Damascus, Syria. He was ousted after a quarter-century in power.

Behind Assad’s swift fall

Syrian rebels, aided by circumstances that were serendipitous and part of a global realignment, overcame years of bloody stalemate

This article is by Kareem Fahim, Loveday Morris, Louisa Loveluck, Greg Miller, Mohamad El Chamaa and Beril Eski

ISTANBUL — Rebels were barreling toward the Syrian capital, but the president’s men were in no mood for the battle.

For more than a week they had watched city after town fall to the rebellion. By Saturday, the insurgents were threatening Homs, a strategic firewall of Bashar al-Assad’s government. Iyad Ahmed, a 22-year-old soldier who said he was paid the equivalent of about \$2 a month, was stationed on the city’s outskirts.

“We didn’t want to fight,” he said.

He was spared the decision. At 10 p.m. Dec. 7, his commander ordered Ahmed and his colleagues to withdraw. “I dropped my weapon and fled,” he said. He shed his uniform in the street.

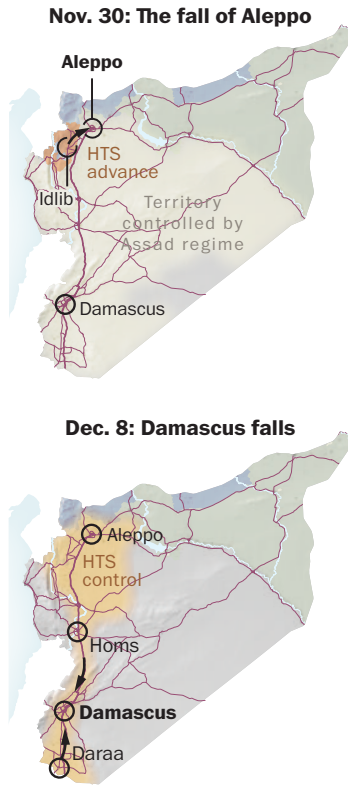
Damascus, the capital, fell to the rebels that night.

The collapse of Assad’s government came more quickly than the rebels had dreamed, the pillars of state power crumbling at the first real push in years from a determined and well-organized opposition force.

The circumstances that conspired to bring down Syria’s old, ossified order were both serendipitous and part of a larger global realignment. Assad’s main military allies — Russia and Iran — abandoned him, distracted by their own troubles and disillusioned by the president’s inability to rally his own forces to the fight. His opponents, led by Hay’at Tahrir al-Sham (HTS), a powerful Islamist rebel faction, and other groups backed by Turkey,

SEE SYRIA ON A12

Tel Aviv hit: Missile fired by Houthis in Yemen damages playground, injures at least 16. **A14**



Democrats’ report finds ethical lapses by justices

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL

Supreme Court justices have regularly failed to identify conflicts of interest that require their recusal and have accepted lavish gifts without reporting them, including previously undisclosed jet and yacht travel by Clarence Thomas, according to Democrats on the Senate Judiciary Committee.

A report released Saturday after a 20-month investigation concludes that Thomas has accepted millions of dollars in gifts during his three decades on the court, including a newly discovered flight to Saranac, New York, and a yacht trip to New York City sponsored by Texas billionaire Harlan Crow in 2021.

“The number, value, and extravagance of the gifts accepted by Justice Thomas have no comparison in modern American history,” the report says. It notes that some of the individuals who gave to Thomas had business before the court.

The investigation also found that the Judicial Conference of the United States, the body that is

SEE ETHICS ON A4



ERIC RISBERG/AP

Baseball’s ‘Man of Steal’ dies

Hall of Famer Rickey Henderson, considered the greatest stolen base threat and leadoff hitter in baseball history, has died at 65. Over a remarkable 25-season MLB career, he was one of the game’s most colorful personalities. **Obituary, A2**

In Rwanda, exiles’ loved ones at risk

U.S. ally targets family and friends of critics abroad, sometimes with torture

BY KATHARINE HOURELD

After he broke out of prison and fled his homeland, Cassien Ntamuhaanga began furiously denouncing Rwanda’s autocratic rulers and meeting with exiled opposition figures. A former radio journalist who’d been jailed on conspiracy charges after his broadcasts had run afoul of the government, he bemoaned the suppression of dissent in Rwanda, one of the United States’ closest allies in Africa.

He took on the government

from his new home about 3,000 miles away, writing online, giving media interviews — and hoping he was safely out of reach. But his family back home was not.

A month after he escaped Rwanda at age 34 in 2017, his cousin disappeared. The body was found soon after, but police would not release it to the family, three relatives recounted.

Ntamuhaanga’s younger brother was detained about two months later. Relatives said he was tortured.

Then police raided his uncle’s

home, arresting the man and his son, who were each sentenced to three years in prison on charges of helping a fugitive. A young female relative picked up in the same raid was separated from her infant child and held for six months. None of them had been politically active. But Ntamuhaanga’s family remained under pressure, facing repeated police raids, until he vanished entirely three years ago.

Their plight was by no means exceptional, according to inter-

SEE RWANDA ON A16

Trump foes fear his retribution is underway

BY HANNAH KNOWLES AND COLBY ITKOWITZ

Since he was elected, President-elect Donald Trump has waffled on his campaign-season vow to punish his enemies when he returns to the White House, declaring this month that his “retribution will be through success.”

But many of Trump’s critics — and targets — fear that his long-promised campaign of retribution has in fact already started.

Trump’s first impulse is to go after people who cross him, and he’ll only be emboldened to do so

in his second term, said Ty Cobb, a White House lawyer during Trump’s first term who has since been critical of the president-elect.

“That’s his instinct, that’s what’s going to happen, and that’s what’s happening now,” Cobb said.

On Wednesday, Trump posted on social media that one of his most vocal Republican critics, former Wyoming congresswoman Liz Cheney, “could be in a lot of trouble,” citing a House GOP report released earlier in the week that recommended the govern-

ment criminally investigate her. The president-elect recently escalated his attacks on another favorite target, the media, by filing a lawsuit against the Des Moines Register and its longtime pollster, accusing them of “election interference” for publishing a poll three days before the election that showed Democratic Vice President Kamala Harris winning Iowa. And Trump’s pick to lead the FBI, Kash Patel, vowed last

SEE TRUMP ON A7

Trump-Putin: Alpha leaders’ next chapter could test world order. **A7**

METRO
D.C. is given \$90 million, largest sum in decades, to fund federal activities.

SPORTS
At last, the Commanders may have a solution for their Eagles problem.



BUSINESS
Your words matter to scam victims. Take this quiz to learn what to say.

BOOK WORLD
“Ancient Christianities” explores how a local sect became Rome’s church.



ARTS & STYLE
With “Nosferatu,” Robert Eggers is driving himself mad to drive us mad.

TRAVEL
A handbook, from booking to checkout, for the civilized hotel guest.

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